India. Ratan thought for a while and said: ‘The quality of service, the guest experience, must be there for every passenger, even if the passenger is seated in the last row.’ The management has made this their ‘central theme’, says Chandrasekaran.

Now, with a new brand logo, very ambitious forward plans, ‘Chandra at the pilot’s wheel, and Ratan fuelling the engines, the Maharaja is sure to pamper its passengers on a flying carpet again’. But achieving it would not be easy. Under the government, the Maharaja, Air India’s mascot, had become synonymous with poor management and service. Bombay House decided to rebrand the airline. As a part of this exercise, in December 2022, Air India hired the ‘London-based brand and design consultancy firm Futurebrands’, which had previously worked on ‘rebranding of American Airlines and British luxury automobile brand Bentley and branding of the 2012 London Olympics’.

Santosh Desai, MD and CEO, Futurebrands India, rationalized the need for a change in the symbol by saying that in a democratized world, the ‘idea of maharaja as a mascot may not be appropriate’. No airline can claim to provide any ‘unique experience’ and the ‘Maharaja’s luxurious experience’ may be an ‘overclaim’.

Both arguments are, however, tenuous. The former flies in the face of the group’s own positioning of its most expensive rooms in the hotels as Maharaja Suites. The argument about ‘unique experience’ is also not tenable as airlines are in competition to provide these to flyers. Vistara makes this claim on its website as well. Campbell said that the Maharaja is ‘relevant to Indian diaspora but not necessarily to the global audiences.’ But now, when the Indian diaspora, including US Vice President Kamala Harris and former UK Prime Minister Rishi Sunak, is making its mark all over the world, Campbell may have missed an important point.

On 11 August 2023, Air India unveiled ‘its new logo called “The Vista”’, which drew inspiration from ‘“Jharokha”-themed windows’ used by the erstwhile Air India.

Unsettling Issues

Echoing public sentiment, cricket commentator Harsha Bhogle had tweeted after the airline was acquired by the Tatas that Air India was ‘in good hands’